

LESSONS LEARNT
Now, a new scholarship scheme for meritorious students in Gujarat

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at least one in each taluka. Even existing private schools could apply. They were to receive Rs 20,000 per child annually from the government, with a budget of Rs 64 crore earmarked for 2023-24. The education department even conducted an entrance test on April 27, in which 465,000 Class 5 students appeared.

Why, then, did it backtrack? The government is offering diplomatic rationalisations, but the history of the aborted scheme could offer clues. Announced in January 2023, the policy was based on the public-private partnership (PPP) model, and had met with stiff resistance from both government teachers and schools across the state. They saw in it a ploy to privatise school education in Gujarat. Their chief concern: why create and fund new schools, instead of investing that amount in the already robust network of government and GIA schools? Priyavadan Korat, member, Gujarat Secondary and Higher Secondary Education Board, says GIA schools get grants on the basis of their Class 10 results. "If meritorious students were to be taken away, scores of schools would not have qualified for grants and, in due course, shut down," he explains.

AMID PROTESTS, GUJARAT GOVT SCRAPS A PLAN TO HAVE SPECIAL SCHOOLS FOR MERIT STUDENTS

Despite the government's climbdown, Korat and unions that together represent 300,000-odd teaching and non-teaching employees in government and aided schools are still wary of its intentions. Under the new scheme, a student enrolled in a government or GIA school will receive an annual scholarship of Rs 5,000 in Classes 6-8, Rs 6,000 in Classes 9-10, and Rs 7,000 in Classes 11-12. If the student is able to secure admission in a private school, the amount will be Rs 20,000, Rs 22,000 and Rs 25,000, respectively. "Giving four times the scholarship to private school children is encouraging private education," says Korat. "Instead, the government should really be investing in its existing institutions."

Gujarat has a network of 32,000 government schools and 7,000 GIA schools across the state. In comparison, there are 14,000 private schools—uneven in quality and spatial distribution. This has been cited as the main reason for scrapping the day school plan. To qualify under the scheme, a school required to have had 80 per cent of its students clear the Class 10 exam in their first attempt, in three of the last five years, among other criteria. As applications started pouring in from private schools, it emerged none qualified in 139—or 63 per cent—of the 225 talukas. Another challenge was political: local strongmen apparently started pressuring ministers and officials to favour schools they owned.

Seeing the hurdles in its rollout and not keen on antagonising thousands of teachers ahead of the Lok Sabha election next year, the Bhupendra Patel-led government finally decided to give the scheme a quiet burial. The education department resolution on June 7 noted that "there were many self-financed schools meeting the merit criterion in some talukas, while few or none…in several others". Thus, meritorious students in some talukas would have had to "travel daily for education, which would not be appropriate," it said, adding that "more students will benefit" under the new scholarship scheme.

Congress spokesperson Manish Doshi claims there's more to it than meets the eye. "The government may have withdrawn the Gyan Setu scheme for now," he says, "but it could return in another form post-elections." Calling it a failed attempt to privatise school education, Doshi adds: "This is a dangerous mindset that wants to upend the socialist system and replace it with unaffordable, inaccessible private education." By way of addressing this charge, the government claims 100 Swami Vivekanand Gyan Shakti Residential Schools are to open in 2023-24 with an initial intake of 300 students each in Class 6—50 of them for tribal children. Ten Raksha Shakti Residential Schools, on the lines of Sainik Schools, will also commence with 500 students each this academic year. An annual budget of Rs 100 crore has been set aside for them. ■